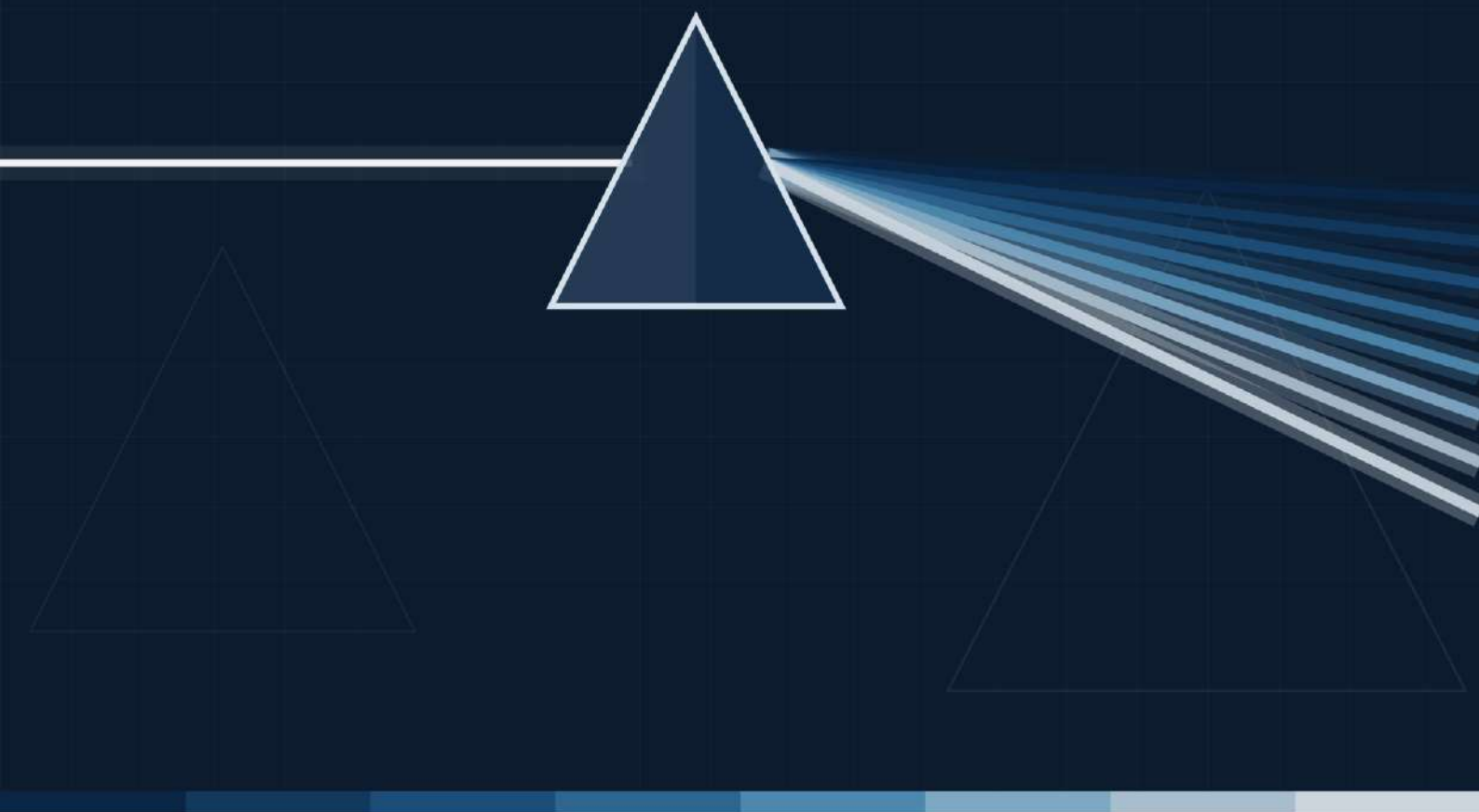


UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY

DISEC

FIRST COMMITTEE



Disarmament and International Security Committee

BACKGROUND GUIDE

AGENDA

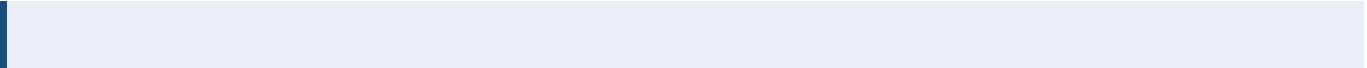
Addressing nuclear proliferation risks in conflict zones,
with special emphasis on the Iran crisis

Information current to 1 October 2026

All sources are official United Nations, IAEA, treaty-body and government documents

AT A GLANCE

Committee	General Assembly First Committee
Membership	All 193 United Nations Member States
Powers	Recommendation only, by simple majority
Agenda	Addressing nuclear proliferation risks in conflict zones, with special emphasis on the Iran crisis
Information current to	1 October 2026
Sources	United Nations, IAEA, CTBTO, international courts and national governments



1. The Committee

1.1 Mandate and composition

The Disarmament and International Security Committee is the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly. It was established under Rule 98 of the Rules of Procedure of the General Assembly, which provides for six Main Committees, and it has existed since the first session of the Assembly in 1946. All 193 Member States are members and each holds one vote. Observers, including the Holy See and the State of Palestine, participate without a vote, as do the International Atomic Energy Agency, the Preparatory Commission for the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty Organization and the Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons.

The Committee meets annually from early October to early November. In a typical session it considers between 50 and 70 draft resolutions and decisions across seven clusters: nuclear weapons, other weapons of mass destruction, outer space, conventional weapons, regional disarmament, the disarmament machinery, and other measures of international security. Drafts approved in Committee are forwarded to the General Assembly plenary, which usually adopts them in early December.

1.2 Legal basis and the limits of this committee

DISEC derives its authority from Chapter IV of the Charter of the United Nations. Delegates should know these provisions precisely, because the whole argument about what this committee may say on Iran turns on them.

Charter provision	Text and significance
Article 11(1)	The General Assembly may consider the general principles of cooperation in the maintenance of international peace and security, including the principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments, and may make recommendations to Members, to the Security Council, or to both.
Article 11(2)	The Assembly may discuss any question relating to international peace and security brought before it by any Member, by the Security Council, or by a non-member State. Any such question on which action is necessary shall be referred to the Security Council either before or after discussion.
Article 12(1)	While the Security Council is exercising the functions assigned to it in respect of any dispute or situation, the Assembly shall not make any recommendation with regard to that dispute or situation unless the Council so requests. In practice this provision has been read narrowly since the 1960s, and the Assembly has debated matters on the Council's agenda.
Article 2(4)	All Members shall refrain in their international relations from the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any State. This is the provision cited by the many States that condemned the June 2025 strikes.

Charter provision	Text and significance
Article 2(7)	Nothing in the Charter authorises the United Nations to intervene in matters essentially within the domestic jurisdiction of any State. This is the provision cited against intrusive verification demands.
Article 51	Nothing in the Charter impairs the inherent right of individual or collective self-defence if an armed attack occurs against a Member, until the Security Council has taken the measures necessary. This is the provision invoked by States that defended the strikes.
Article 41	The Security Council, not the General Assembly, may decide on measures not involving the use of armed force, including the complete or partial interruption of economic relations. All the Iran sanctions resolutions were adopted under this Article.

The practical consequence is that DISEC recommends and does not decide. It cannot impose sanctions, cannot authorise or prohibit the use of force, cannot order inspections, and cannot admit States to treaties. A draft resolution in this committee that purported to do any of those things would be outside the committee's competence and should be ruled accordingly. What the committee can do is substantial: it can set out the law as States understand it, create reporting obligations that States accept voluntarily, request studies from the Secretary-General, establish groups of governmental experts and open-ended working groups, and refer a question to the Security Council under Article 11(2).

THE LIMIT OF THIS COMMITTEE

DISEC cannot impose sanctions, authorise or prohibit the use of force, order inspections, or admit States to treaties. What it can do is state the law as States understand it, create voluntary reporting obligations, commission studies and expert groups, and refer a question to the Security Council under Article 11(2).

1.3 Related bodies and how they differ

Body	Mandate and relationship to DISEC
IAEA	Autonomous intergovernmental organisation established in 1957, reporting to the General Assembly and, where appropriate, the Security Council. Its 35-member Board of Governors applies safeguards and makes findings of non-compliance. DISEC cannot instruct the Agency.
Conference on Disarmament	The single multilateral disarmament negotiating forum, with 65 members, based in Geneva. It works by consensus and has agreed no new treaty since the CTBT in 1996. It reports annually to the General Assembly.
UNODA	The United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs, headed by a High Representative, supports the First Committee, the Conference on Disarmament and the treaty review processes, and maintains the Secretary-General's depositary records.

Body	Mandate and relationship to DISEC
UNIDIR	The United Nations Institute for Disarmament Research, an autonomous institute in Geneva that produces technical studies often cited in First Committee debate.
Disarmament Commission	A deliberative body of the whole that meets in New York and produces recommendations by consensus. It has agreed substantive recommendations only rarely since 1999.
Security Council	The only organ that can adopt binding measures. The 1737 Committee and its Panel of Experts, revived in 2025, sit under it, not under DISEC.

1.4 Procedure in this committee

Drafts are introduced by main sponsors, open for co-sponsorship until a deadline set by the Chair, and voted in clusters. Voting may be as a whole or paragraph by paragraph if a separate vote is requested, and recorded votes are the norm on contested nuclear texts. Delegates should expect three recurring procedural fights on this agenda: requests for separate votes on paragraphs naming a particular State, no-action motions, and disputes over whether language reproduces an agreed formulation from a previous resolution or introduces a new one. Agreed language matters: a phrase lifted verbatim from General Assembly resolution 2625 (XXV) or from an NPT Review Conference final document is far easier to defend than a freshly drafted sentence.

2. The Agenda Explained

2.1 Reading the agenda title

The agenda has three components, and a resolution has to address all three or it will be incomplete.

Nuclear proliferation risks. Proliferation is conventionally divided into horizontal spread, meaning the acquisition of nuclear weapons by States that do not have them, and vertical growth, meaning the expansion of existing arsenals. A third category, acquisition by non-State actors, is governed by Security Council resolution 1540 (2004). This agenda adds a fourth that the classical framework barely covers: the risk created when nuclear material and nuclear installations are located inside an active conflict, whether or not anyone is trying to build a weapon.

Conflict zones. The term has no settled legal definition. International humanitarian law speaks of international and non-international armed conflict; the Security Council speaks of situations threatening international peace and security. For this agenda, four distinct situations are in scope and each raises a different legal question. In Iran, declared and safeguarded facilities were struck by two States, and the inspectorate has since lost access. In Ukraine, the largest nuclear power plant in Europe sits on a front line and has lost external power 26 times. On the Korean peninsula, a State that left the NPT now has an unmonitored and expanding production capacity. Across the Middle East more broadly, one State remains outside the NPT entirely and the proposed regional zone has never been negotiated.

Special emphasis on the Iran crisis. Iran is the case where every strand of this agenda meets: a non-nuclear-weapon State party to the NPT, with the largest stockpile of highly enriched uranium ever accumulated by such a State, whose facilities were attacked while under safeguards, whose cooperation with the inspectorate is suspended by its own domestic law, and whose file has split the Security Council so completely that the Council cannot agree whether its own sanctions are in force.

2.2 Technical vocabulary

Delegates will be held to precise use of these terms. Confusing enrichment with weaponisation, or a safeguards finding with evidence of a weapons programme, is the most common substantive error in this debate.

Term	Definition
Enrichment	The process of raising the proportion of the fissile isotope uranium-235 above its natural level of about 0.7 per cent, usually in gas centrifuges operating on uranium hexafluoride (UF ₆). The same equipment produces reactor fuel and weapons material; only the duration of the process differs.
Low enriched uranium	Uranium enriched below 20 per cent U-235. Most power reactors use fuel enriched to between 3 and 5 per cent.
Highly enriched uranium	Uranium enriched to 20 per cent U-235 or above. The IAEA uses 20 per cent as the definitional threshold. Weapons-grade is conventionally about 90 per cent, but a device can be built with less.
Significant quantity	The IAEA's accounting unit: the approximate amount of material from

Term	Definition
	which the manufacture of a nuclear explosive device cannot be excluded. It is 25 kg of contained U-235 for highly enriched uranium and 8 kg for plutonium. About 42 kg of 60 per cent material contains one significant quantity.
Breakout time	The estimated time needed to produce one significant quantity of weapons-grade material from a declared stockpile. It is an analytical estimate, not a legal category, and it measures material production only, not warhead design, testing or delivery.
Comprehensive Safeguards Agreement	The agreement required of every non-nuclear-weapon State party to the NPT, concluded on the model of IAEA document INFCIRC/153, covering all nuclear material in all peaceful activities in the State.
Additional Protocol	The voluntary protocol modelled on INFCIRC/540, adopted in 1997, which adds declarations on the whole fuel cycle and complementary access to locations beyond declared facilities. It is what allows the Agency to look for undeclared activity rather than only audit declared activity.
Modified Code 3.1	The provision of subsidiary arrangements requiring design information to be provided as soon as a decision to construct a facility is taken, rather than 180 days before nuclear material is introduced.
Broader conclusion	The Agency's annual finding, available only for States with both a safeguards agreement and an Additional Protocol in force, that all nuclear material in the State remains in peaceful activities.
Continuity of knowledge	The unbroken chain of inspection, containment and surveillance that allows the Agency to account for material over time. Once broken, it can be restored only by re-measurement, which may be impossible if material has moved.
Snapback	The mechanism in paragraphs 11 and 12 of Security Council resolution 2231 (2015) under which a participant State's notification of significant non-performance causes previously terminated sanctions resolutions to be re-applied unless the Council votes within 30 days to continue their termination.

3. The Treaty Framework

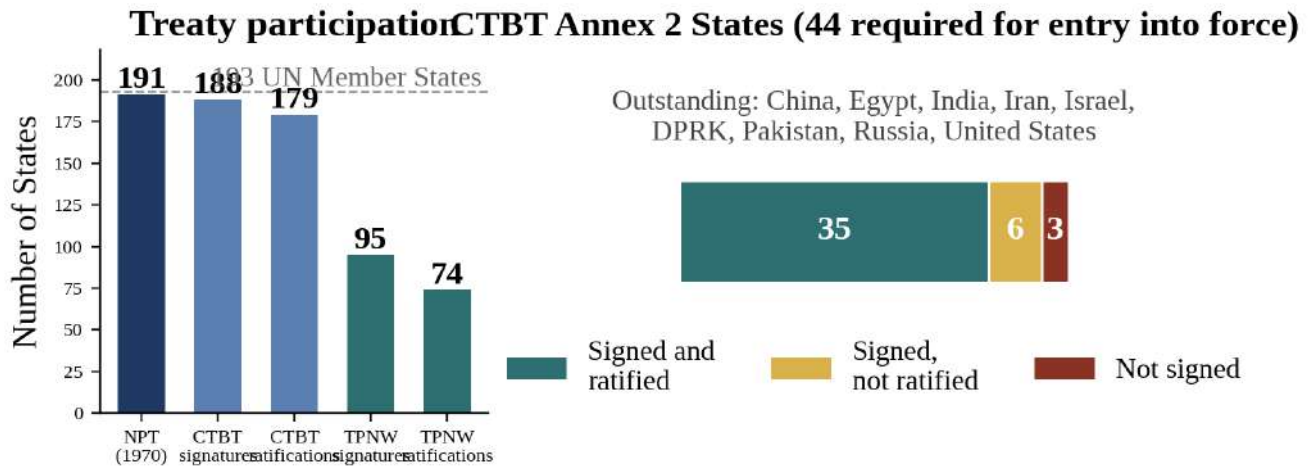


Figure 1. Participation in the three principal nuclear treaties, and the Annex 2 problem that keeps the CTBT out of force. Sources: UNODA depositary records; CTBTO.

3.1 The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons

The NPT was opened for signature on 1 July 1968 and entered into force on 5 March 1970. It has 191 States parties, making it the most widely adhered to arms control treaty in existence. Four States are outside it: India, Israel and Pakistan never joined, and the Democratic People's Republic of Korea announced withdrawal in 2003. The 1995 Review and Extension Conference extended the Treaty indefinitely, in a package that also included a resolution on the Middle East and a set of principles and objectives for non-proliferation and disarmament.

The Treaty rests on a bargain between two classes of party. A nuclear-weapon State is defined in Article IX(3) by a historical fact: one that manufactured and exploded a nuclear weapon or other nuclear explosive device prior to 1 January 1967. That definition fixes the class at five States, which are also the five permanent members of the Security Council. Every other party is a non-nuclear-weapon State.

Article-by-article

Article	Obligation
I	Each nuclear-weapon State party undertakes not to transfer nuclear weapons or control over them to any recipient, and not to assist, encourage or induce any non-nuclear-weapon State to manufacture or acquire them.
II	Each non-nuclear-weapon State party undertakes not to receive, manufacture or otherwise acquire nuclear weapons, and not to seek or receive assistance in their manufacture. This is the core non-proliferation obligation, and the question in the Iran file is whether anything Iran has done crosses it.
III	Each non-nuclear-weapon State party undertakes to accept IAEA safeguards on all source and special fissionable material in all peaceful nuclear activities, for the exclusive purpose of verifying the

Article	Obligation
	fulfilment of its Article II obligations. Agreements were to be concluded within 18 months of entry into force for that party.
IV	Nothing in the Treaty affects the inalienable right of all parties to develop research, production and use of nuclear energy for peaceful purposes without discrimination and in conformity with Articles I and II. Paragraph 2 commits parties to facilitate the fullest possible exchange of equipment, materials and information. This is the article Iran invokes for a right to enrich.
V	Potential benefits from peaceful applications of nuclear explosions are to be made available to non-nuclear-weapon States. The article is effectively dead, superseded by the test ban.
VI	Each party undertakes to pursue negotiations in good faith on effective measures relating to cessation of the nuclear arms race at an early date and to nuclear disarmament, and on a treaty on general and complete disarmament. In its 1996 advisory opinion the International Court of Justice held unanimously that this entails an obligation to pursue in good faith and bring to a conclusion negotiations leading to nuclear disarmament in all its aspects.
VII	Nothing affects the right of groups of States to conclude regional treaties assuring the total absence of nuclear weapons in their territories. This is the basis for the five existing nuclear-weapon-free zones and for the proposed Middle East zone.
VIII	Amendment requires the approval of a majority of all parties including all nuclear-weapon States and all Board members. Paragraph 3 provides for review conferences at five-year intervals.
IX	Defines the nuclear-weapon State category by the 1 January 1967 cut-off.
X(1)	Each party has the right to withdraw if it decides that extraordinary events related to the subject matter have jeopardised its supreme interests. It must give three months' notice to all parties and to the Security Council, including a statement of the extraordinary events. Only the DPRK has ever invoked this.

The review cycle and its record

Review conferences are held every five years under Article VIII(3). The 2000 Conference agreed 13 practical steps including an unequivocal undertaking by the nuclear-weapon States to accomplish the total elimination of their arsenals. The 2010 Conference adopted a 64-point action plan and remains the last conference to agree a consensus outcome. The 2015 Conference failed over language on the Middle East zone. The 2022 Conference, held late because of the pandemic, failed when Russia objected to text on Zaporizhzhya.

The eleventh Review Conference met at United Nations Headquarters from 27 April to 22 May 2026, presided over by Ambassador Do Hung Viet of Viet Nam. The President tabled four successive versions

of a draft outcome, culminating in NPT/CONF.2026/CRP.2/Rev.4, but did not put it forward for adoption. The Conference closed on 22 May 2026 without a consensus outcome, the fourth failure in five cycles. The Secretary-General expressed disappointment in a statement the same day. Delegates should note what this means in practice: there is no agreed multilateral text on attacks against nuclear facilities, on the Iran file, or on Zaporizhzhya that a resolution can simply cite. That vacuum is part of why this agenda has come to the First Committee.

3.2 The IAEA safeguards system

The IAEA was established by its Statute, which entered into force on 29 July 1957. Article II states the twin objective: to accelerate and enlarge the contribution of atomic energy to peace, health and prosperity, and to ensure, so far as it is able, that assistance provided by it is not used to further any military purpose. Article III.A.5 gives it the authority to apply safeguards. The Agency has 180 Member States and is governed by a 35-member Board of Governors that meets five times a year and by an annual General Conference.



Figure 2. How a safeguards question escalates. Each step is a legal act with its own threshold. Source: IAEA Statute and INFCIRC/153.

Three documents define the system. INFCIRC/153, agreed in 1972, is the model comprehensive safeguards agreement: the State declares all nuclear material, the Agency verifies the declaration by material accountancy, containment and surveillance, and the Agency's conclusion is about the non-diversion of declared material. INFCIRC/540, the Model Additional Protocol adopted in 1997 after the discovery of Iraq's clandestine programme, extends the Agency's reach to information about the entire fuel cycle and to complementary access at short notice, allowing conclusions about the absence of undeclared material and activities. INFCIRC/66-type agreements apply item-specific safeguards to particular facilities in States outside the NPT, and are what covers some facilities in India, Pakistan and Israel.

The enforcement provision is Article XII.C of the Statute. Where inspectors report non-compliance, the Director General transmits the report to the Board, the Board calls on the State to remedy the non-compliance, and the Board reports the non-compliance to all Members and to the Security Council and the General Assembly. The Board has made such a finding seven times in its history: against Iraq in 1991, Romania in 1992, the DPRK in 1993, Libya in 2004, Iran in 2006, Syria in 2011 and Iran again on 12 June 2025.

The system's limits matter for this debate. Safeguards verify material, not intent. The Agency has no police power, no right of forcible entry, and no capacity to act where a State denies access. Where there is no Additional Protocol in force, the Agency cannot draw the broader conclusion that there is no undeclared material. As of the most recent Safeguards Implementation Report, the Agency has concluded

that all nuclear material remained in peaceful activities in fewer than 80 of the roughly 140 States with safeguards agreements in force, precisely because the rest lack an Additional Protocol.

3.3 The Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty

The CTBT was adopted by the General Assembly on 10 September 1996 and opened for signature on 24 September 1996. Article I prohibits any nuclear weapon test explosion or any other nuclear explosion, anywhere, and prohibits causing, encouraging or participating in one. Article IV establishes a verification regime of 321 monitoring stations and 16 radionuclide laboratories using seismic, hydroacoustic, infrasound and radionuclide technologies, together with on-site inspection. More than 90 per cent of the network is built and certified, and it detected all six DPRK tests, in 2006, 2009, 2013, twice in 2016 and in 2017.

Article XIV is the obstacle. The Treaty enters into force 180 days after all 44 States listed in Annex 2, those that participated in the 1996 negotiations and held nuclear reactors at the time, have deposited instruments of ratification. As of 2026, 188 States have signed and 179 have ratified, but 35 of the 44 Annex 2 States have ratified. Six Annex 2 States have signed without ratifying: China, Egypt, Iran, Israel, the Russian Federation and the United States. Three have not signed: the DPRK, India and Pakistan. The Russian Federation withdrew its ratification in November 2023, stating that it was mirroring the position of the United States, and remains a signatory bound by the obligation in the Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties not to defeat the object and purpose of a signed treaty. Article XIV conferences are convened to promote entry into force, most recently in 2025.

3.4 The Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons

The TPNW was adopted on 7 July 2017 by a vote of 122 in favour, one against (the Netherlands) and one abstention (Singapore), in a conference boycotted by all nuclear-armed States and most of their allies. It opened for signature on 20 September 2017 and entered into force on 22 January 2021, ninety days after the fiftieth ratification. As of 2026 it has 95 signatories and 74 States parties.

Article 1 prohibits developing, testing, producing, acquiring, possessing or stockpiling nuclear weapons, and also stationing, installation or deployment of another State's weapons on a party's territory, and assisting or encouraging any prohibited act. Article 4 sets out pathways for a possessor State to join, either by eliminating weapons before joining or by joining and then eliminating them under a legally binding time-bound plan. Articles 6 and 7 create obligations of victim assistance and environmental remediation, the first in a nuclear treaty.

No nuclear-armed State is a party and none accepts that the Treaty reflects customary international law. The dividing line in First Committee debate is between States that regard the TPNW as the delivery of Article VI and States that regard it as a parallel instrument that weakens the NPT. Any resolution on this agenda that cites the TPNW approvingly will lose the support of the nuclear-weapon States and most alliance members; any that ignores it will lose a large part of the Non-Aligned Movement.

3.5 Nuclear-weapon-free zones

Article VII of the NPT preserves the right of groups of States to conclude regional treaties assuring the total absence of nuclear weapons in their territories. General Assembly resolution 3472 B (XXX) of 1975 set out the accepted definition. Five zones are in force, covering the entire southern hemisphere and substantial parts of the northern, together with Mongolia's single-State status recognised by the Assembly in resolution 55/33 S.

Treaty	Scope, dates and protocols
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Treaty	Scope, dates and protocols
Treaty of Tlatelolco (1967)	Latin America and the Caribbean. Opened for signature 14 February 1967, in force 22 April 1968; 33 parties. Protocol I binds extra-regional States with territories in the zone, Protocol II binds the nuclear-weapon States to respect the zone and not to use or threaten to use nuclear weapons against its parties. All five have ratified Protocol II.
Treaty of Rarotonga (1985)	South Pacific. In force 11 December 1986; 13 parties. Bans stationing and testing and the dumping of radioactive waste at sea. The United States has signed but not ratified the protocols.
Treaty of Bangkok (1995)	South-East Asia. In force 27 March 1997; 10 parties. Uniquely extends to exclusive economic zones and continental shelves, which is why no nuclear-weapon State has yet signed the protocol.
Treaty of Pelindaba (1996)	Africa. In force 15 July 2009; 44 parties. Named after the South African site where devices were built and dismantled. Requires full-scope IAEA safeguards and prohibits attacks against nuclear installations in the zone.
Treaty of Semipalatinsk (2006)	Central Asia. In force 21 March 2009; 5 parties. The first zone wholly in the northern hemisphere and the first requiring an Additional Protocol of every party. All five nuclear-weapon States signed the protocol in 2014.
Mongolia (2000)	Single-State nuclear-weapon-free status, recognised by General Assembly resolution 55/33 S and by the five nuclear-weapon States in a joint statement of 2012.

Two features of the zones matter for this agenda. First, the Pelindaba Treaty contains the only binding treaty prohibition on armed attack or threat of attack against nuclear installations in a region, in Article 11, which States opposed to the June 2025 strikes cite as evidence of an emerging norm. Second, the zone protocols are the only legally binding negative security assurances in existence; everything else is a unilateral declaration or the political language of Security Council resolution 984 (1995). The Middle East zone, discussed in Section 6.3, would be the sixth and is the only one proposed for a region where a State possesses nuclear weapons.

3.6 Security Council resolution 1540 and non-State actors

Resolution 1540 (2004) was adopted unanimously under Chapter VII on 28 April 2004. It decides that all States shall refrain from providing any form of support to non-State actors that attempt to develop, acquire, manufacture, possess, transport, transfer or use nuclear, chemical or biological weapons and their means of delivery, and shall adopt and enforce effective laws to that effect, together with domestic controls over related materials, including accounting, physical protection, border controls and export controls. It is the only instrument that imposes binding non-proliferation obligations on every State regardless of treaty membership.

Resolution 2663 (2022), adopted unanimously on 30 November 2022 under Chapter VII, extended the mandate of the 1540 Committee and its Group of Experts until 30 November 2032 and required comprehensive reviews of implementation, the first before December 2027. The related instruments are

the Convention on the Physical Protection of Nuclear Material of 1980 and its 2005 Amendment, which entered into force in 2016 and extends protection obligations to material in domestic use, storage and transport and to facilities themselves, and the International Convention for the Suppression of Acts of Nuclear Terrorism of 2005.

3.7 The law on attacks against nuclear installations

This is the part of the framework most directly engaged by the agenda, and the part where the law is least settled.

The IAEA General Conference has addressed it repeatedly. Resolution GC(XXIX)/RES/444 of 1985 and resolution GC(XXXIV)/RES/533 of 1990 provide that any armed attack on and threat against nuclear facilities devoted to peaceful purposes constitutes a violation of the principles of the Charter of the United Nations, international law and the Statute of the Agency. The Director General recalled both resolutions by name in his statement to the Board on 13 June 2025, the morning of the first strikes on Iran.

In international humanitarian law, Article 56 of Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions of 1977 protects works and installations containing dangerous forces, specifically dams, dykes and nuclear electrical generating stations, from attack even where they are military objectives, if such attack may cause the release of dangerous forces and consequent severe losses among the civilian population. The protection ceases in defined circumstances, including where a nuclear generating station provides electric power in regular, significant and direct support of military operations and attack is the only feasible way to terminate that support. The provision covers nuclear electrical generating stations; it does not by its terms cover enrichment plants or research reactors, which is one of the gaps this agenda could address. Article 85(3)(c) makes an attack on such works a grave breach when it causes excessive civilian loss.

Delegates should note the asymmetry in the Iran case. The facilities struck in June 2025 were declared facilities under a comprehensive safeguards agreement, subject to Agency inspection. Several contained nuclear material at the time. None was a nuclear electrical generating station; Bushehr, which is one, was not targeted. Whether the Article 56 protection, the General Conference resolutions, or neither applies to an enrichment plant is a live legal question on which States in this committee take opposing positions.

THE GAP IN THE LAW

Article 56 of Additional Protocol I protects nuclear electrical generating stations. It does not by its terms protect enrichment plants, conversion plants or research reactors. The facilities struck in Iran in June 2025 were declared and safeguarded, and none of them was a power reactor. Closing that gap is one of the few things this committee could usefully propose.

3.8 The negotiating machinery and what it has not produced

The Conference on Disarmament in Geneva has 65 members and operates by consensus on both substance and its programme of work. It negotiated the Chemical Weapons Convention and the CTBT, and has agreed no treaty since 1996. Three items have been blocked for decades and each is relevant here.

A fissile material cut-off treaty. General Assembly resolution 48/75 L of 1993 called for a non-discriminatory, multilateral and internationally and effectively verifiable treaty banning the production of fissile material for nuclear weapons. The Conference adopted the Shannon mandate in March 1995 and has not begun negotiations. The dispute is whether such a treaty should cover existing stocks, which States with smaller stocks insist on and States with larger ones resist. A cut-off treaty would be the single measure most directly relevant to this agenda, because it would place enrichment and reprocessing in all States under a common prohibition for weapons purposes rather than leaving the obligation asymmetric.

Negative security assurances. Non-nuclear-weapon States have sought a legally binding instrument under which nuclear-weapon States undertake not to use or threaten to use nuclear weapons against them. Security Council resolution 984 (1995) took note of unilateral declarations but created no binding obligation, and the declarations themselves contain caveats. The absence of such assurances is the standard answer given when States are asked why they will not accept further verification obligations.

Prevention of an arms race in outer space. Blocked since 1985, and relevant here because command, control and early warning systems increasingly depend on space assets.

Delegates should know this record, because a draft resolution calling on the Conference on Disarmament to commence negotiations is the standard low-cost gesture in First Committee texts, and it has been made in effectively identical terms every year since 1996 without result.

4. Historical Context

4.1 From the bomb to the bargain, 1945 to 1970

The first General Assembly resolution ever adopted, resolution 1(I) of 24 January 1946, established a commission to make proposals for eliminating atomic weapons from national armaments. The Baruch Plan of 1946 proposed international ownership of fissile material and was rejected by the Soviet Union, which tested its first device in 1949. The United Kingdom followed in 1952, France in 1960 and China in 1964. President Eisenhower's Atoms for Peace address to the General Assembly on 8 December 1953 proposed the bargain that became the IAEA: assistance with civil nuclear technology in exchange for controls.

The Cuban missile crisis of 1962 and the prospect of a world with dozens of nuclear-armed States produced the Partial Test Ban Treaty of 1963 and then the NPT. Ireland had tabled the first proposals in the Assembly from 1958, which is why the Irish resolutions are still cited in NPT preambular language. The Treaty's asymmetry, five recognised possessors and everyone else, was accepted in 1968 as the price of preventing wider spread and was tied to the disarmament undertaking in Article VI.

4.2 The cases that shaped the regime

Case	What happened and what it established
Israel, Dimona (from 1958)	A reactor built with French assistance outside any safeguards. Israel has never joined the NPT and maintains a declared policy of ambiguity. The resulting regional asymmetry is the root of the Middle East zone question.
India (1974 and 1998)	A device tested in 1974 using plutonium from a Canadian-supplied research reactor, which prompted the creation of the Nuclear Suppliers Group in 1975. Weapons tests in 1998 followed by Pakistani tests the same month.
Osirak, Iraq (1981)	Israel struck the Osirak reactor near Baghdad. Security Council resolution 487 (1981), adopted unanimously on 19 June 1981, strongly condemned the attack as a clear violation of the Charter and the norms of international conduct, and called on Israel to place its nuclear facilities under IAEA safeguards. This is the clearest precedent on attacks against safeguarded facilities.
Iraq after 1991	Inspections under Security Council resolution 687 (1991) revealed a clandestine enrichment programme at declared and undeclared sites that comprehensive safeguards had not detected. This failure produced the Additional Protocol.
South Africa (1989 to 1991)	Six devices built and then dismantled before accession to the NPT in July 1991, verified by the Agency. The only case of a State giving up an indigenous arsenal.
Ukraine, Belarus, Kazakhstan (1991 to 1996)	Soviet weapons on their territory transferred to Russia; all three acceded to the NPT as non-nuclear-weapon States. The Budapest

Case	What happened and what it established
	Memorandum of 5 December 1994 recorded security assurances from the United States, the United Kingdom and Russia, a precedent now cited on all sides.
DPRK (1993 to 2006)	Board finding of non-compliance in 1993, announced withdrawal in 2003, first test in 2006. The only State to leave the NPT and build weapons.
Libya (2003 to 2004)	Announced on 19 December 2003 that it would eliminate its programmes; centrifuges and design documentation removed in 2004; Board noted the case closed in 2004.
Syria, Al Kibar (2007 and 2011)	A suspected undeclared reactor destroyed by an Israeli strike in September 2007. The Board found Syria in non-compliance on 9 June 2011. No Security Council resolution condemned the strike, a contrast with 1981 that States cite in both directions.

4.3 The Iran file, 2002 to 2015

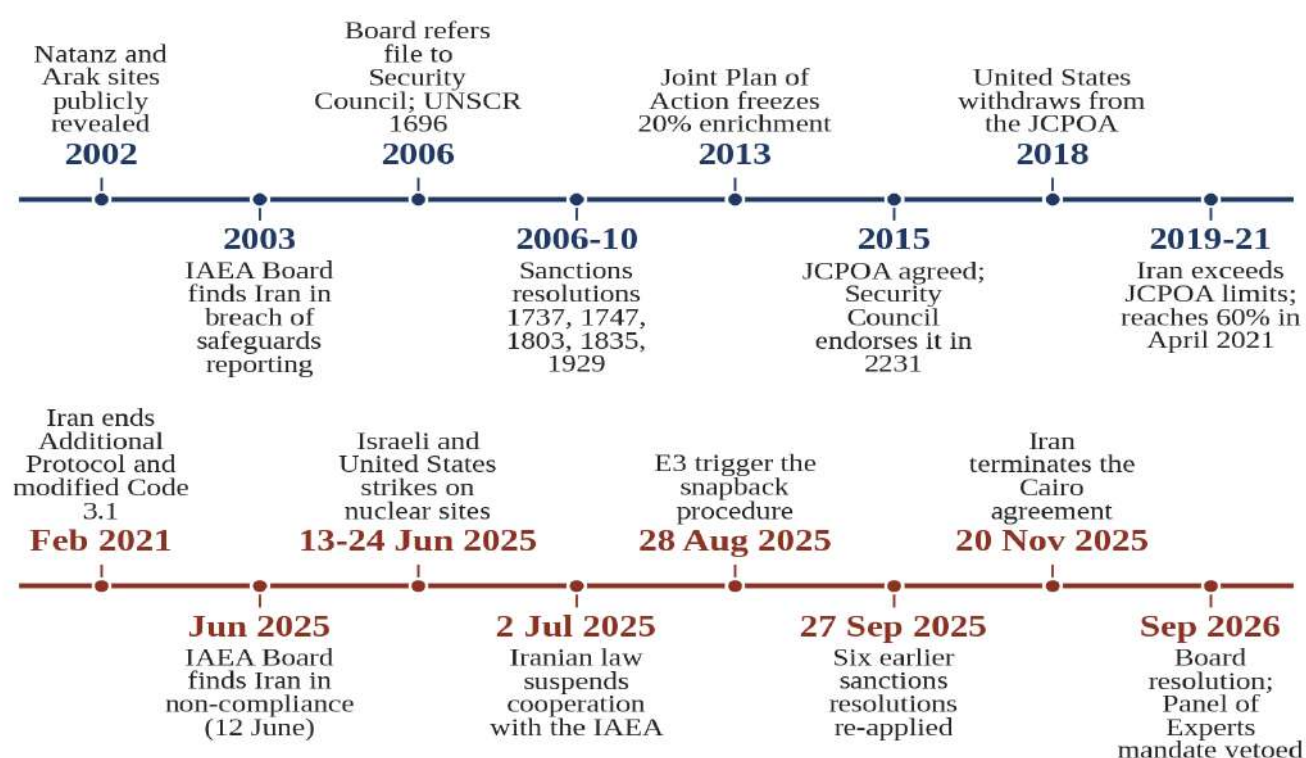


Figure 3. The Iran nuclear file. Upper track: 2002 to 2021. Lower track: 2021 to 2026. Sources: IAEA Board documents; Security Council records.

In August 2002 an opposition group publicly identified an enrichment facility under construction at Natanz and a heavy water plant at Arak. Iran had not declared either, and the Agency's subsequent investigation established that undeclared nuclear material had been imported and processed over a period of years. On 24 September 2005 the Board found that Iran's failures constituted non-compliance in the

context of Article XII.C of the Statute, and on 4 February 2006 it reported the matter to the Security Council.

The Council then adopted six resolutions. Resolution 1696 (2006) of 31 July 2006 invoked Article 40 of Chapter VII to make the suspension of enrichment mandatory. Resolution 1737 (2006) of 23 December 2006 imposed the first sanctions and created the 1737 Committee. Resolutions 1747 (2007), 1803 (2008), 1835 (2008) and 1929 (2010) extended them, with 1929 adding a Panel of Experts, an arms embargo and measures on shipping and finance.

Negotiations produced the Joint Plan of Action of 24 November 2013, under which Iran froze enrichment above 5 per cent and diluted its 20 per cent stock, and then the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action, agreed in Vienna on 14 July 2015 between Iran and China, France, Germany, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom, the United States and the European Union. Its principal limits were: enrichment capped at 3.67 per cent U-235 for 15 years; a total enriched uranium stockpile capped at 300 kg of UF₆, equivalent to 202.8 kg of uranium mass; no enrichment at Fordow for 15 years; installed centrifuges reduced from about 19,000 to 6,104 with 5,060 operating at Natanz; the Arak reactor core removed and the reactor redesigned; provisional application of the Additional Protocol; and continuous Agency monitoring of the whole supply chain. Security Council resolution 2231 (2015), adopted unanimously on 20 July 2015, endorsed the deal, terminated the six earlier resolutions on Implementation Day, and set out in paragraphs 11 and 12 the snapback procedure, together with a termination date of 18 October 2025 for the resolution itself.

4.4 Collapse, 2018 to 2024

The United States announced withdrawal from the JCPOA on 8 May 2018 and re-imposed national sanctions. The Agency continued to report Iranian compliance through 2018 and most of 2019. From May 2019 Iran began announced, reversible breaches: exceeding the stockpile cap, then the enrichment cap, then resuming enrichment at Fordow, then operating advanced centrifuges. In August 2020 the United States attempted to invoke snapback; the Council President concluded that the notification could not be acted upon because the United States had ceased to be a participant State, and the attempt failed.

Two steps in February 2021 were decisive for verification. Iran ceased implementing the Additional Protocol and ceased implementing modified Code 3.1, ending the Agency's early access to design information for new facilities. In April 2021 Iran began enriching to 60 per cent at Natanz, and later at Fordow, becoming the only non-nuclear-weapon State ever to produce uranium at that level. Through 2022 and 2023 the Agency also pursued unresolved questions about uranium particles found at three undeclared locations, which Iran has never satisfactorily explained.

5. The Iran Crisis as it Stands

5.1 The material

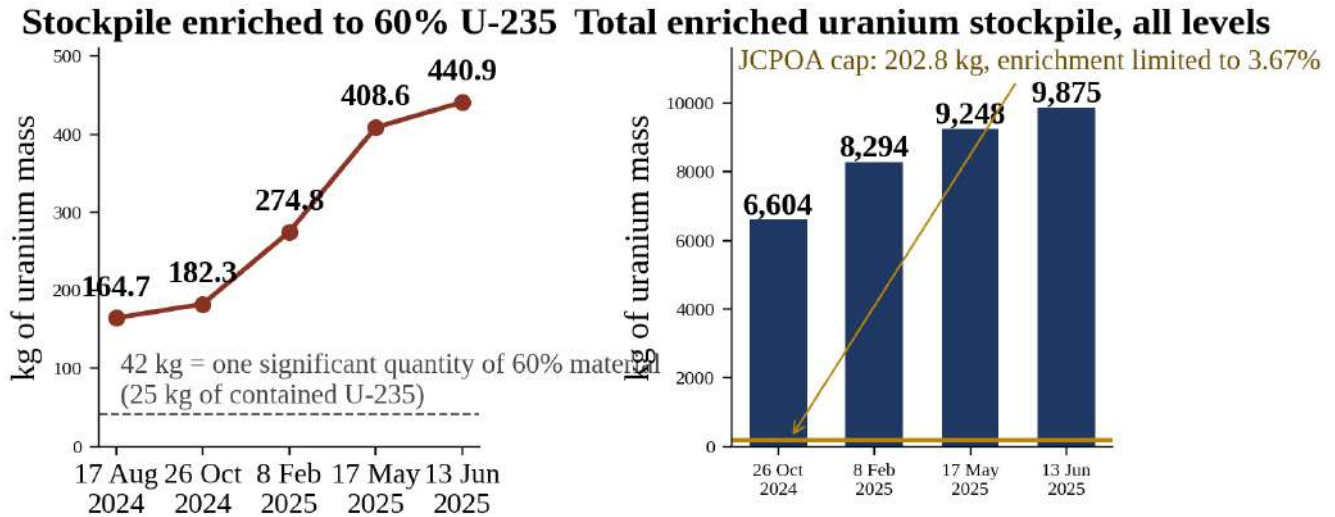


Figure 4. Iran's declared enriched uranium holdings at the last five IAEA verification dates before inspections stopped. Source: IAEA Board reports GOV/2024/68, GOV/2025/13, GOV/2025/29 and GOV/2026/50.

The Agency's last complete verification was based on information up to 12 June 2025. Its estimate of Iran's total enriched uranium stockpile as of 13 June 2025 was 9,874.9 kg of uranium mass, comprising 9,040.5 kg in the form of UF₆ and 834.4 kg in other chemical forms. Within the UF₆ figure: 2,391.1 kg enriched up to 2 per cent, 6,024.4 kg up to 5 per cent, 184.1 kg up to 20 per cent, and 440.9 kg enriched up to 60 per cent U-235.

Three comparisons give those numbers meaning. First, the total is roughly 48 times the JCPOA stockpile cap of 202.8 kg. Second, 440.9 kg of 60 per cent material is more than ten significant quantities as the Agency defines them, and the European Union stated at the Board on 10 September 2025 that this is more than ten significant quantities. Third, Iran is the only non-nuclear-weapon State ever to have produced and accumulated uranium enriched to 60 per cent, a point the Director General has made repeatedly and which the February 2026 Board report repeats.

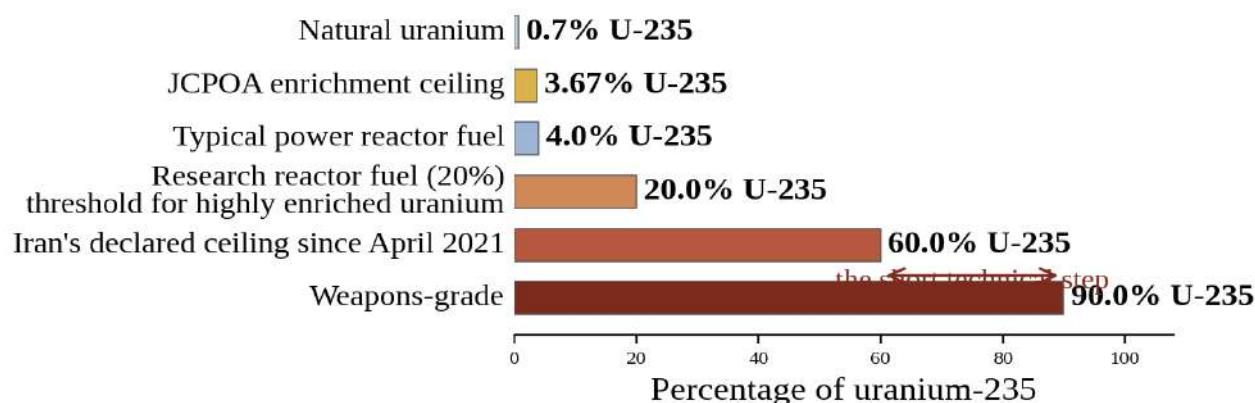


Figure 5. Enrichment levels. The separative work needed to go from 60 to 90 per cent is a small fraction of that needed to reach 60 per cent from natural uranium, which is why the 60 per cent stockpile is the central fact in this file.

THE CENTRAL FIGURES

As of 13 June 2025: a total enriched uranium stockpile of 9,874.9 kg of uranium mass, about 48 times the JCPOA cap of 202.8 kg, including 440.9 kg enriched to 60 per cent U-235, more than ten significant quantities. Since that date the Agency has been unable to verify the size, composition or whereabouts of any of it.

5.2 What the JCPOA required, and where each limit now stands

The agreement of 14 July 2015 was a set of specific, measurable physical limits with defined durations. Setting them against the position in 2026 is the clearest way to see what has been lost.

Parameter	JCPOA limit	Position in 2026
Enrichment level	3.67% U-235 for 15 years	Up to 60% since April 2021; the Agency cannot verify current levels
Enriched uranium stockpile	300 kg of UF ₆ , that is 202.8 kg of uranium mass	9,874.9 kg of uranium mass as of 13 June 2025, about 48 times the cap; unverified since
Stockpile at 60%	Not contemplated; no production above 3.67% permitted	440.9 kg as of 13 June 2025, more than ten significant quantities; location unknown to the Agency
Installed centrifuges	6,104 IR-1 at Natanz, of which 5,060 operating; no others	Advanced IR-6 cascades installed at Natanz and Fordow before June 2025; inventories unverified
Fordow	No enrichment and no nuclear material for 15 years; converted to a research centre	Main 60% enrichment site from 2023; struck on 22 June 2025; no access since

Parameter	JCPOA limit	Position in 2026
Arak and Khondab	Original core removed and rendered unusable; reactor redesigned to minimise plutonium	Reactor under construction; the Agency last accessed the site on 14 May 2025
Reprocessing	No reprocessing of spent fuel for 15 years	Suspension required again by the re-applied Council resolutions; unverified
Additional Protocol	Applied provisionally from Implementation Day, with ratification expected	Implementation ceased in February 2021; not applied since
Modified Code 3.1	Applied, giving early design information on new facilities	Implementation ceased in February 2021
Agency monitoring	Continuous monitoring of centrifuge manufacture, uranium mines and mills, and the whole supply chain for up to 25 years	Ended; the Agency has received no nuclear material accountancy reports since 13 June 2025
Procurement channel	A Council working group vetting nuclear-related transfers	Inoperative; the Panel of Experts was never constituted and its mandate lapsed on 26 September 2026

5.3 The June 2025 strikes

On the morning of 13 June 2025 the Agency was informed of a military operation launched by Israel that included attacks on nuclear facilities in Iran. The attacks continued from 13 to 24 June 2025. On 22 June 2025 the United States conducted attacks on three Iranian nuclear facilities, at Fordow, Natanz and Esfahan.

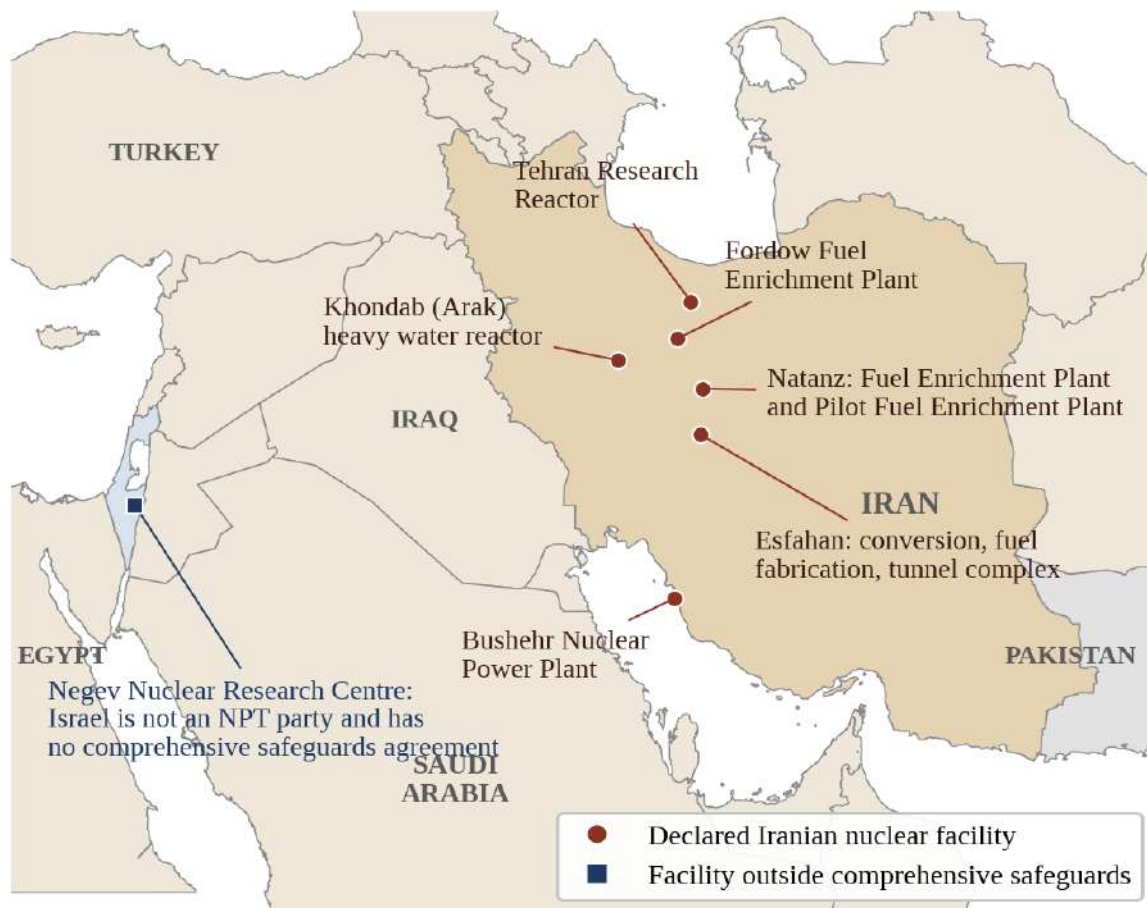


Figure 6. Iran's declared nuclear facilities and the regional context. Map prepared for this guide from public boundary data; facility locations from IAEA Board reports.

The Director General addressed the Board on 13 June, the Security Council the same day, the Board again at a special session on 16 June, and the Board at an extraordinary session on 23 June. The Agency's reporting establishes the following. At Natanz, the above-ground Pilot Fuel Enrichment Plant, one of the two plants where Iran was producing 60 per cent material, was destroyed; the electrical substation, main power supply building and backup generators were destroyed on 13 June; the loss of power to the underground cascades may have damaged the centrifuges there; radiation levels outside the site remained normal, but there is radiological and chemical contamination inside the facility, where the principal hazard is chemical toxicity from uranium hexafluoride and its reaction products. At Esfahan the uranium conversion facility, the fuel plate fabrication plant, the fuel manufacturing plant, the enriched uranium dioxide powder plant and the central chemical laboratory were damaged. Fordow showed no visible damage until the United States strikes of 22 June. The Khondab heavy water reactor, under construction, and the Tehran Research Reactor were damaged in the wider campaign. Bushehr Nuclear Power Plant was not targeted.

The Agency assesses that seven declared facilities that had contained declared nuclear material before the attacks were affected: the Fordow Fuel Enrichment Plant, the Natanz facilities, the uranium conversion facility, the fuel manufacturing plant, the fuel plate fabrication plant and the enriched uranium dioxide powder plant. The Agency stopped verification activities at the start of the attacks and, by the end of June 2025, had withdrawn all its inspectors from Iran for safety reasons.

5.4 The verification gap

On 2 July 2025 the President of Iran signed into force a law adopted by the Majlis suspending cooperation with the Agency, under which any inspection requires the prior approval of the Supreme National Security Council. The Director General's position, stated to the Board and repeated by the European Union on 10 September 2025, is that implementation of a comprehensive safeguards agreement cannot be suspended under any circumstances and that national law cannot create obligations for the Agency.

At the end of August 2025 the Agency resumed inspections at Bushehr. On 9 September 2025 the Director General and the Foreign Minister of Iran signed an agreement in Cairo on practical steps on safeguards implementation, which the Director General described as providing an understanding of the procedures for inspections, notifications and safeguards implementation covering all declared facilities and material. Iran's Supreme National Security Council approved it on 15 September but made implementation subject to its prior approval. Following the Board's resolution of 20 November 2025, Iran informed the Director General by letter dated 20 November 2025 that the Cairo agreement was no longer valid and was to be regarded as terminated. The Agency reports that Iran took no steps to implement it.

The position as reported to the Board on 1 September 2026 in document GOV/2026/50 is as follows. The Agency has had no access to any of Iran's four declared enrichment facilities to perform verification activities. It cannot verify the size, composition or whereabouts of the stockpile of enriched uranium in Iran. It cannot verify whether Iran has suspended enrichment-related activities and heavy-water-related projects as required by the re-applied Security Council resolutions. It has not received nuclear material accountancy reports since 13 June 2025. After 28 February 2026 it stopped conducting verification activities in Iran in accordance with the safeguards agreement. The Agency has lost continuity of knowledge over the inventory of highly enriched material. In its own words, the lack of information about this nuclear material and access to facilities to verify it is a matter of proliferation concern that needs to be addressed with the utmost urgency.

5.5 Snapback and the split in the Security Council

On 28 August 2025 France, Germany and the United Kingdom notified the Security Council of significant non-performance by Iran, triggering the procedure in paragraph 11 of resolution 2231. The procedure gives the Council 30 days to adopt a resolution continuing the termination of the earlier sanctions; if it does not, those resolutions are re-applied automatically, and because the continuation resolution requires an affirmative vote, no permanent member can prevent the re-application by veto.

The Republic of Korea, as Council President, introduced a draft to continue sanctions relief on 8 September 2025; it was put to the vote on 19 September and not adopted. On 26 September 2025 the Council voted on a draft submitted by China and the Russian Federation that would have extended resolution 2231 and the JCPOA for six months to 18 April 2026; it was not adopted. The E3 stated that resolutions 1696, 1737, 1747, 1803, 1835 and 1929 were reinstated as of 20:00 Eastern Daylight Time on 27 September 2025, that is 00:00 GMT on 28 September.

China, Iran and the Russian Federation set out the contrary position in a letter to the Council dated 18 October 2025: that the E3 had ceased to perform their own JCPOA commitments and therefore lacked standing to invoke paragraph 11, that resolution 2231 expired on its own terms on 18 October 2025, and that all nuclear-related provisions, measures, restrictions and mechanisms were permanently terminated on that date, the Council's consideration of the Iranian nuclear issue concluded, and the item removed from the list of matters of which the Council is seized.

The dispute has produced an institutional deadlock with no modern parallel. The Secretariat has proceeded on the basis that the sanctions were re-applied, circulating a note to correspondents and

preparing the Secretary-General's report on resolution 2231, which some members have criticised. Under-Secretary-General DiCarlo briefed the Council on 23 December 2025 and recorded that Member States expressed differing viewpoints on the status of the resolution. The 1737 Committee was nominally revived with a Panel of Experts, but the Council never approved the panel members proposed by the Secretary-General, and the panel never operated. On 17 September 2026 the Council voted on a United States draft to extend the panel's mandate before its expiry on 26 September; the vote was 11 in favour, 2 against and 2 abstentions, with the negative votes cast by China and the Russian Federation and abstentions by Pakistan and Somalia, so the draft was not adopted. There is now no independent United Nations mechanism monitoring implementation of sanctions that half the Council says are in force and the other half says do not exist.

TWO READINGS OF THE SAME TEXT

France, Germany and the United Kingdom hold that resolutions 1696, 1737, 1747, 1803, 1835 and 1929 were re-applied on 27 September 2025 and that the 1737 Committee and its Panel of Experts were restored. China, Iran and the Russian Federation hold that resolution 2231 expired on 18 October 2025, that all measures were permanently terminated, and that the Council has concluded its consideration of the file. Nothing has resolved the difference.

5.6 The Board of Governors in 2025 and 2026

On 12 June 2025, one day before the strikes, the Board adopted a resolution finding Iran in non-compliance with its safeguards obligations, the first such finding since 2006, by 19 votes in favour. On 20 November 2025 the Board adopted resolution GOV/2025/71, which required Iran to comply fully and without qualification with its safeguards agreement and requested the Director General to report regularly, including information on the verification of Iran's uranium stockpile, its locations, quantities, chemical forms and enrichment levels, and the inventories of centrifuges and related equipment. The Board adopted further resolutions on 10 June 2026 and on 9 September 2026 urging Iran to cooperate. In the June 2026 vote, 21 of the 35 Board members voted in favour. The 2026 resolutions were submitted by France, Germany and the United Kingdom together with the United States.

5.7 The positions of the parties, in their own terms

Delegates representing these States should know how each frames its case, because committee debate will reproduce these arguments.

Iran maintains that it neither seeks nor intends to acquire nuclear weapons and that such weapons have no place in its security doctrine, a position the Foreign Minister restated to the Conference on Disarmament in Geneva on 17 February 2026. In the same statement he described the right recognised in Article IV of the NPT to develop, research, produce and use nuclear energy for peaceful purposes as inherent, non-negotiable and legally established. Iranian officials have said that Iran will negotiate the degree of enrichment but not the existence of enrichment, and that ending enrichment is a red line. Iran also argues that the strikes on its safeguarded facilities, and the lack of guarantees against their repetition, are the cause of the suspension of cooperation rather than its pretext.

The United States has held that any agreement must prohibit enrichment in Iran altogether, and that the right to peaceful nuclear energy under Article IV does not include a right to enrich. It defended the June 2025 strikes and has stated that Iran's programme was set back substantially. It drafted the 2026 Security Council resolution on the Panel of Experts and co-sponsored the Board resolutions.

France, Germany and the United Kingdom triggered snapback, describing it as a last resort taken in view of continued nuclear escalation, and stated that re-imposition is not the end of diplomacy and that

they will continue to work towards a new diplomatic solution. They judged the Cairo agreement insufficient because it set no timelines for access to the attacked sites.

The Russian Federation and China reject the validity of the snapback, maintain that resolution 2231 expired on 18 October 2025, voted against the Panel of Experts extension, and argue that the Council's consideration of the file has concluded. Both also opposed the attacks on nuclear facilities.

The European Union, speaking at the Board on 10 September 2025, recorded that Iran's overall stockpile was 48 times the JCPOA limit, that the inventory of highly enriched uranium can no longer be quantified or located by the Agency, and that Iran's safeguards obligations stem from the NPT and are non-negotiable. It condemned threats against the Director General and espionage charges against inspectors.

6. Other Conflict Zones

6.1 Zaporizhzhya and nuclear safety in Ukraine

The Zaporizhzhya Nuclear Power Plant is the largest in Europe, with six VVER-1000 reactors. It has been under Russian military control since early March 2022 while remaining on Ukrainian territory, and the Agency has maintained a continuous presence of experts at the site since September 2022. All six reactors have been in shutdown for more than three years, but they still require electricity for cooling pumps, instrumentation and spent fuel pools.

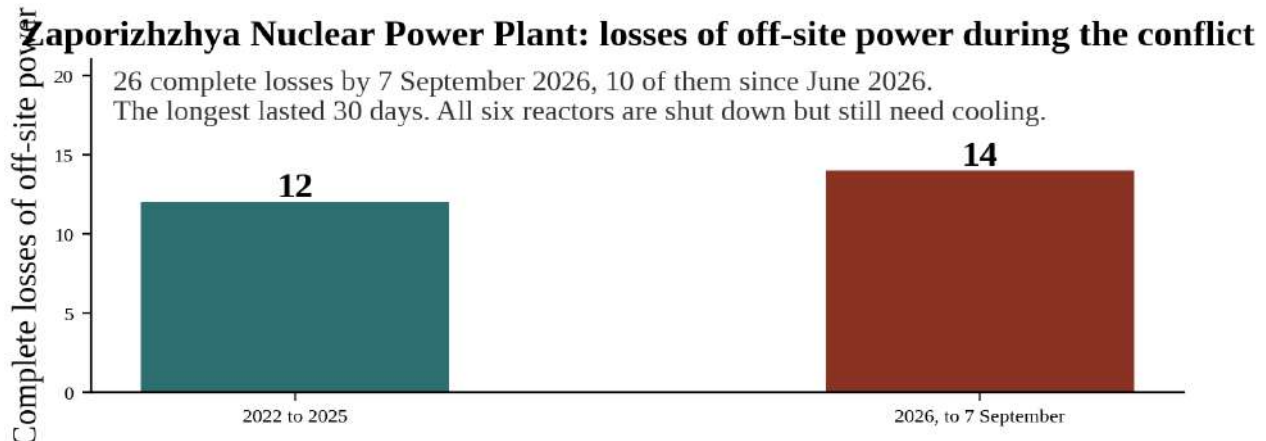


Figure 7. Complete losses of off-site power at Zaporizhzhya during the conflict. Source: IAEA Director General updates on the situation in Ukraine.

The Director General set out Seven Indispensable Pillars of nuclear safety and security during an armed conflict in March 2022, of which the fourth requires a secure off-site power supply from the grid for all nuclear sites. He set out Five Concrete Principles for protecting the plant to the Security Council on 30 May 2023, of which the third requires that all efforts be made to ensure off-site power remains available and secure at all times.

By 7 September 2026 the plant had suffered 26 complete losses of off-site power during the conflict, 10 of them since June 2026 and 14 since April 2026. The longest, in late 2025, lasted 30 days, during which the plant ran on emergency diesel generators alone. On 20 August 2026 the plant lost its last remaining 330 kV line; the Agency was told on 28 August that on-site diesel could support operations for about ten days. Off-site power was restored on the evening of 7 September 2026 after repairs to the Ferosplavna-1 line. The Director General has stated that the frequency of these interruptions and the reliance on diesel generators violate both the Seven Pillars and the Five Principles. A drone exploded at a bus stop used by plant staff on 18 August 2026.

Zaporizhzhya is the reason the 2022 NPT Review Conference failed, and it is the strongest argument available to delegates who want this committee to address the physical protection of facilities rather than only the behaviour of States suspected of proliferation.

6.2 The Democratic People's Republic of Korea

The DPRK acceded to the NPT in 1985, concluded a safeguards agreement only in 1992, was found in non-compliance by the Board in 1993, announced withdrawal in 1993 and again in 2003, and tested devices in 2006, 2009, 2013, twice in 2016 and in 2017. The Agency has had no inspectors in the country

since 2009 and builds its assessments entirely from satellite imagery, open sources and DPRK state media.

The Agency reported to the Board on 28 August 2026 that a new uranium enrichment facility has been built at the Yongbyon complex, a two-storey structure that could house up to 28 centrifuge cascades, and that an expanded annex at the Kangson enrichment site near Pyongyang appears to have begun operating in January 2026. The 5MW(e) reactor at Yongbyon appeared to be in its seventh irradiation cycle. The Director General told the Board on 7 September 2026 that the continued operation of enrichment facilities at Kangson and Yongbyon, together with the reported further expansion of the production of weapons-grade nuclear material, is a cause for serious concern, and that these activities violate Security Council resolutions.

The DPRK's own position, stated by its mission in Vienna in 2025 and restated at the 70th IAEA General Conference in September 2026, is that its status as a nuclear weapons State is irreversible and absolute, that nuclear weapons status was written into its constitution in 2023, and that the Agency has no legal right to interfere in the internal affairs of a State outside the NPT. At the September 2026 General Conference, 103 Member States voted for a resolution expressing growing concern at the increased level of activity at DPRK nuclear facilities; Russia and China voted against.

6.3 The Middle East zone free of weapons of mass destruction

General Assembly resolution 3263 (XXIX) of 1974, co-sponsored by Egypt and Iran, first called for a nuclear-weapon-free zone in the region. The 1995 NPT Review and Extension Conference adopted a resolution on the Middle East as part of the indefinite extension package, sponsored by the three depositary States. The 2010 Review Conference mandated a conference on the zone for 2012, which was never convened, and that failure caused the 2015 Review Conference to collapse.

General Assembly decision 73/546 of 22 December 2018, submitted by Egypt on behalf of the Arab Group, entrusted the Secretary-General with convening a conference and requested annual sessions until a legally binding treaty is concluded. Israel and the United States voted against. The first session met from 18 to 22 November 2019 and adopted a political declaration. The sixth session met from 17 to 21 November 2025 under the presidency of Morocco, and the seventh is scheduled for November 2026 at Headquarters. The Arab League, Iran, and four of the five nuclear-weapon States attend. Israel does not participate. Until it does, the zone cannot be negotiated, and the Arab Group's position is that the asymmetry between Israel's unsafeguarded facilities and the obligations borne by every other State in the region is the regional proliferation problem.

6.4 South Asia and other theatres

India and Pakistan are outside the NPT, have tested, and have fought repeated crises since 1998 in a theatre with short flight times and no equivalent of the Cold War crisis management architecture. Neither has signed the CTBT. Both place some civil facilities under INFCIRC/66-type safeguards. Resolutions on this agenda that speak of universalising the NPT have to reckon with the fact that three such States cannot join except as non-nuclear-weapon States, which none will do.

7. Key Issues for Debate

7.1 Does Article IV confer a right to enrich?

Article IV speaks of the inalienable right to develop research, production and use of nuclear energy for peaceful purposes, in conformity with Articles I and II. It does not mention enrichment. Iran and much of the Non-Aligned Movement read the right as covering the complete fuel cycle, since enrichment is a form of production of nuclear energy and the article forbids discrimination. The United States reads it as a right to peaceful technology, not to any particular technology, and notes that most States with nuclear power do not enrich. A middle position, reflected in proposals for fuel banks and in the IAEA Low Enriched Uranium Bank at Oskemen in Kazakhstan, is that assured supply can satisfy the interest the right protects. No authoritative adjudication exists, and the question cannot be settled by this committee, but how a resolution phrases the peaceful uses paragraph will determine which blocs can support it.

7.2 Can safeguards be suspended?

Iran's law of 2 July 2025 conditions inspections on national approval. The Agency's position is that a comprehensive safeguards agreement is an international obligation that cannot be suspended under any circumstances and that domestic law cannot alter it, which is the ordinary rule reflected in Article 27 of the Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties. The counter-argument is not legal but practical: safeguards presuppose the physical safety of inspectors and of the facilities they inspect, and the Agency itself withdrew its inspectors on safety grounds. A resolution could usefully address what happens to verification obligations when a safeguarded facility is attacked, which no existing instrument answers.

7.3 Are attacks on safeguarded nuclear facilities lawful?

The positions are irreconcilable as a matter of law and both have support. Against: IAEA General Conference resolutions GC(XXIX)/RES/444 and GC(XXXIV)/RES/533 declare such attacks a violation of the Charter, international law and the Statute; Security Council resolution 487 (1981) unanimously condemned the Osirak strike; Article 56 of Additional Protocol I protects installations containing dangerous forces; and an attack that disperses radioactive or chemically toxic material engages the rules on indiscriminate attack. For: Article 51 preserves the inherent right of self-defence, and States invoking it argue that a facility producing material with no civil justification is a military objective. The practical question for this committee is narrower and more answerable: whether to seek a standing norm, or a reporting mechanism, or a request to the International Law Commission, rather than to adjudicate the June 2025 case.

7.4 Verification after a gap

Continuity of knowledge, once lost, cannot be recreated by resuming inspections. Material must be re-measured, and where it has been moved, buried or mixed, re-measurement may be impossible. The Agency has lost that continuity for Iran's highly enriched uranium. Any eventual settlement will therefore need a special verification arrangement going beyond a standard comprehensive safeguards agreement: forensic environmental sampling, reconstruction of operating records, and possibly access to sites damaged in the attacks. There is precedent in the Iraq and Libya cases, and the Agency has said it is ready to undertake monitoring and verification in the DPRK if called upon.

7.5 Sanctions, enforcement and the credibility of the Council

The sanctions re-applied in September 2025 include an enrichment and reprocessing suspension requirement, an arms embargo, missile restrictions, asset freezes and travel bans, and cargo inspection provisions. Whether they are in force is contested, and there is no panel to monitor them. Two questions follow for this committee. First, what a General Assembly body can usefully say when the Council is deadlocked: the Uniting for Peace precedent of resolution 377 A (V) exists but is politically explosive and applies to a failure to act on threats to the peace, not to a disagreement about whether a resolution is in force. Second, whether sanctions have been a tool of non-proliferation or an obstacle to it, a question on which the record since 2018 is read in opposite ways by the two halves of the Council.

7.6 Cascade risk and the regional response

If a threshold State crosses into weapons possession, or if the regional security guarantee framework is seen to have failed, other States may reconsider. Several regional States have civil nuclear programmes and have declined to rule out enrichment. The classic non-proliferation answer is a combination of security assurances, fuel supply guarantees and regional zones. All three are weak at present: negative security assurances exist only in zone protocols and unilateral declarations, the fuel bank is small, and the regional zone process has produced no treaty in 52 years.

7.7 Article VI and the credibility of the bargain

Non-nuclear-weapon States argue, and have argued at every Review Conference since 2000, that non-proliferation obligations cannot be tightened indefinitely while disarmament obligations go unmet. The arsenals of the nuclear-weapon States are being modernised, New START expired in February 2026 with no successor negotiation, the CTBT remains out of force, and no fissile material cut-off treaty has been negotiated in the Conference on Disarmament since the Shannon mandate of 1995. Any resolution that addresses only non-proliferation will be read by a large bloc as one-sided, and any that addresses only disarmament will be opposed by the nuclear-weapon States.

8. Case Studies

8.1 Osirak, 1981: the precedent on attacking a safeguarded reactor

The Osirak research reactor near Baghdad was supplied by France, was subject to IAEA safeguards, and had been inspected. Israel destroyed it on 7 June 1981, arguing anticipatory self-defence. The Security Council adopted resolution 487 (1981) unanimously on 19 June 1981, strongly condemning the attack as a clear violation of the Charter of the United Nations and the norms of international conduct, recognising Iraq's right to appropriate redress, and calling upon Israel to place its nuclear facilities under IAEA safeguards. The General Assembly adopted a parallel resolution. *Relevance: the only unanimous Security Council condemnation of an attack on a safeguarded facility, and the text every State opposing the June 2025 strikes cites. Note also what followed: the inspections after 1991 revealed that the Iraqi programme had continued and expanded after 1981.*

8.2 South Africa, 1989 to 1991: verified rollback

South Africa built six gun-type devices and a seventh partially, then dismantled them, closed the Y-Plant enrichment facility, acceded to the NPT on 10 July 1991 as a non-nuclear-weapon State, concluded a comprehensive safeguards agreement in September 1991, and in March 1993 publicly disclosed the former programme. The Agency verified the completeness of the declaration over the following two years, a process that required reconstructing the production history of highly enriched uranium from operating records. *Relevance: the only indigenous arsenal ever dismantled, and the clearest demonstration that verification of a past programme is possible where the State cooperates fully.*

8.3 Libya, 2003 to 2004: negotiated dismantlement

Libya announced on 19 December 2003 that it would eliminate its weapons of mass destruction programmes. Centrifuge components, uranium hexafluoride and weapons design documentation acquired through the A. Q. Khan network were removed, the Board was informed of the undeclared activities, and Libya signed an Additional Protocol in March 2004 and applied it provisionally. *Relevance: cited in opposite directions. Supporters of negotiated solutions cite it as proof that dismantlement can be bought with sanctions relief and security assurances. Opponents of disarmament cite the fate of the Libyan government in 2011 as the reason no State should surrender a deterrent, an argument the DPRK has made explicitly.*

8.4 The DPRK, 1993 to 2006: the Article X precedent

The DPRK is the only State to have invoked Article X. It announced withdrawal in March 1993, suspended the announcement one day before it took effect, and announced again on 10 January 2003 that the earlier suspension was lifted, claiming the withdrawal took effect the following day. States parties have never agreed whether that withdrawal was legally effective, and the question of what procedure should govern withdrawal, including whether the Security Council should automatically consider any notification, has been on every Review Conference agenda since. *Relevance: the unresolved withdrawal question is directly engaged whenever an NPT party's compliance is contested, and Iranian parliamentarians have at various points raised withdrawal.*

8.5 Zaporizhzhya, 2022 to 2026: a civil plant inside a war

Covered in Section 6.1. *Relevance: it shifts the agenda from intent to consequence. Nobody alleges that either party is seeking to divert material at Zaporizhzhya; the risk is a radiological release caused by the ordinary conduct of hostilities. The Seven Pillars and Five Principles are the only operational standards that exist, and they are not binding.*

8.6 Iraq after 1991: why the Additional Protocol exists

Iraq was a party to the NPT with a comprehensive safeguards agreement in force, and the Agency's inspections of its declared facilities had found nothing amiss. After the 1991 war, inspections under Security Council resolution 687 (1991) revealed a large clandestine enrichment programme using calutrons and centrifuges at undeclared sites, in some cases adjacent to declared ones. *Relevance: the defining demonstration that verifying declared material is not the same as verifying the absence of undeclared material. It produced INFCIRC/540 in 1997, and it is why the absence of an Additional Protocol in Iran since February 2021 matters independently of the June 2025 strikes.*

9. Bloc Positions and Research Pointers

Delegates must verify their own government's current position. The following are starting points and the documents in which each position is stated.

Bloc or State	Position and where to find it
P5 collectively	The five issued a joint statement on 3 January 2022 affirming that a nuclear war cannot be won and must never be fought. They oppose the TPNW, defend their Article VI record by reference to arsenal reductions since 1986, and resist any verification obligation applied to themselves.
United States	Opposes enrichment in Iran in any form; defended the June 2025 strikes; drafted the 2026 Panel of Experts resolution; has not ratified the CTBT; maintains extended deterrence commitments to over 30 States.
Russian Federation	Rejects the validity of the snapback; de-ratified the CTBT in November 2023; operates and controls Zaporizhzhya; opposed the 2026 NPT outcome language on nuclear safety; supplies and operates Bushehr.
China	Rejects the snapback; signed but has not ratified the CTBT; advocates a no-first-use treaty and opposes extended deterrence arrangements; voted against the 2026 DPRK General Conference resolution.
France, Germany, United Kingdom	Triggered snapback on 28 August 2025; co-sponsored the Board resolutions of November 2025, June 2026 and September 2026; state that re-imposition is not the end of diplomacy.
Iran	Article IV right to enrich is inherent and non-negotiable; will negotiate the level but not the existence of enrichment; cooperation with the Agency conditioned on the law of 2 July 2025 and on guarantees against further attacks; signatory but not party to the CTBT.
Non-Aligned Movement	120 members; insists on the primacy of Article IV and Article VI, on the Middle East zone, and on the principle that non-proliferation measures must not restrict peaceful uses. The NAM working paper to each Review Conference is the authoritative statement.
Arab Group	Sponsors decision 73/546 and the annual resolution on the risk of nuclear proliferation in the Middle East; the central demand is Israeli accession to the NPT and comprehensive safeguards.
TPNW States parties	74 parties, concentrated in Latin America, Africa, South-East Asia and the Pacific; argue the humanitarian consequences framework and victim assistance obligations under Articles 6 and 7.

Bloc or State	Position and where to find it
NATO and allied non-nuclear States	Rely on extended deterrence; several host weapons; have not joined the TPNW; support the Additional Protocol as the verification standard and generally support the stepping-stone approach.
Threshold and newcomer States	States with civil programmes and no enrichment: watch for positions on fuel supply assurances, the IAEA LEU Bank and the right to a complete fuel cycle.
India and Pakistan	Outside the NPT; have not signed the CTBT; India maintains a no-first-use declaration and a safeguards agreement covering designated civil facilities; both will resist language on universalisation that implies accession as non-nuclear-weapon States.
Israel	Not an NPT party; policy of ambiguity; does not attend the Middle East zone conference; conducted the strikes of 13 to 24 June 2025.
Japan and the Republic of Korea	Non-nuclear-weapon States under extended deterrence with large civil programmes; Japan sponsors the annual resolution on the elimination of nuclear weapons and hosts the Article XIV process; both face DPRK capability directly.

10. Questions a Resolution Must Answer

1. What does Article IV of the NPT guarantee, and can the committee state a position on the fuel cycle that both the Non-Aligned Movement and the nuclear-weapon States can accept?
2. Should the committee affirm, restate or go beyond IAEA General Conference resolutions GC(XXIX)/RES/444 and GC(XXXIV)/RES/533 on armed attacks against nuclear facilities, and should any such norm cover enrichment and conversion plants as well as power reactors?
3. What obligations survive an attack on a safeguarded facility: of the attacked State to continue accepting inspections, of the attacking State to permit assessment, and of the Agency toward inspector safety?
4. How should continuity of knowledge be restored where it has been lost, and what special verification arrangements beyond a standard comprehensive safeguards agreement would be required?
5. Should the Additional Protocol become the universal verification standard, and if so what is offered in exchange to the States that regard it as intrusive?
6. What should happen when the Security Council cannot agree whether its own resolutions are in force, and is there any role for the General Assembly that does not exceed Article 12?
7. How can the Seven Indispensable Pillars and the Five Concrete Principles be given firmer status, and should they be extended to all nuclear installations in any armed conflict?
8. What verifiable steps on Article VI would make a strengthened non-proliferation package politically saleable to the non-nuclear-weapon States?
9. What should the committee say about the NPT withdrawal procedure in Article X, and about the consequences of withdrawal for material and facilities acquired while a party?
10. How should the Middle East zone process be advanced given that one State of the region does not participate, and what incentives or assurances could change that?
11. What is the role of fuel supply assurances, the IAEA LEU Bank and multilateral fuel cycle arrangements in reducing the demand for national enrichment?
12. What reporting, transparency or confidence-building measures could the committee create that do not require Security Council action and that a deadlocked Council cannot block?

Annex A. Chronology

Dates in bold are the ones most likely to be contested in debate.

The regime

Date	Event
24 Jan 1946	General Assembly resolution 1(I), the first resolution of the Assembly, establishes a commission on atomic energy
8 Dec 1953	Atoms for Peace address to the General Assembly
29 Jul 1957	IAEA Statute enters into force
1 Jul 1968	NPT opened for signature
5 Mar 1970	NPT enters into force
1972	INFCIRC/153, the model comprehensive safeguards agreement, agreed
7 Jun 1981	Israeli strike on the Osirak reactor, Iraq
19 Jun 1981	Security Council resolution 487 (1981) unanimously condemns the strike
1985 and 1990	IAEA General Conference resolutions GC(XXIX)/RES/444 and GC(XXXIV)/RES/533 on armed attacks against nuclear facilities
1991	Iraq's clandestine programme uncovered under Security Council resolution 687 (1991)
10 Jul 1991	South Africa accedes to the NPT after dismantling six devices
11 May 1995	NPT extended indefinitely, with the resolution on the Middle East
1995	Shannon mandate agreed in the Conference on Disarmament for a fissile material cut-off treaty
24 Sep 1996	CTBT opened for signature; not in force
1997	INFCIRC/540, the Model Additional Protocol, adopted
28 Apr 2004	Security Council resolution 1540 (2004) adopted unanimously under Chapter VII
2010	NPT Review Conference adopts a 64-point action plan, the last consensus outcome
7 Jul 2017	TPNW adopted by 122 votes to 1 with 1 abstention

Date	Event
22 Dec 2018	General Assembly decision 73/546 on the Middle East zone conference
22 Jan 2021	TPNW enters into force
Mar 2022	Seven Indispensable Pillars of nuclear safety during armed conflict set out
30 Nov 2022	Security Council resolution 2663 (2022) extends the 1540 Committee to 2032
30 May 2023	Five Concrete Principles for Zaporizhzhya presented to the Security Council
Nov 2023	Russian Federation withdraws its CTBT ratification
22 May 2026	Eleventh NPT Review Conference closes without a consensus outcome

The Iran file

Date	Event
Aug 2002	Natanz and Arak publicly revealed
24 Sep 2005	IAEA Board finds Iran in non-compliance under Article XII.C
4 Feb 2006	Board reports the matter to the Security Council
31 Jul 2006	Security Council resolution 1696 (2006) makes suspension mandatory under Article 40
2006 to 2010	Resolutions 1737, 1747, 1803, 1835 and 1929 impose and extend sanctions
24 Nov 2013	Joint Plan of Action
14 Jul 2015	JCPOA agreed in Vienna
20 Jul 2015	Security Council resolution 2231 (2015) endorses it, with snapback in paragraphs 11 and 12
16 Jan 2016	Implementation Day; the six earlier resolutions terminate
8 May 2018	United States announces withdrawal from the JCPOA
May 2019 onward	Iran begins announced breaches of the limits
Aug 2020	United States snapback attempt is not acted upon by the Council

Date	Event
Feb 2021	Iran ceases implementing the Additional Protocol and modified Code 3.1
Apr 2021	Enrichment to 60% begins at Natanz
17 May 2025	Last full quarterly verification: 408.6 kg at 60%, total stockpile 9,247.6 kg
12 Jun 2025	Board finds Iran in non-compliance, 19 votes in favour
13 to 24 Jun 2025	Israeli strikes on nuclear facilities; United States strikes on Fordow, Natanz and Esfahan on 22 June
End Jun 2025	The Agency withdraws all inspectors from Iran for safety reasons
2 Jul 2025	Iranian law suspending cooperation with the Agency enters into force
Late Aug 2025	Inspections resume at Bushehr only
28 Aug 2025	France, Germany and the United Kingdom notify the Council, triggering snapback
9 Sep 2025	Cairo agreement on practical steps signed in Cairo
19 and 26 Sep 2025	Council fails to adopt drafts that would have continued sanctions relief
27 Sep 2025	Resolutions 1696, 1737, 1747, 1803, 1835 and 1929 re-applied, on the E3 reading
18 Oct 2025	Date on which China, Iran and the Russian Federation say resolution 2231 expired and all measures terminated
20 Nov 2025	Board resolution GOV/2025/71; Iran terminates the Cairo agreement the same day
28 Feb 2026	The Agency stops conducting verification activities in Iran under the safeguards agreement
10 Jun 2026	Board resolution demanding information and access, 21 votes in favour
1 Sep 2026	Report GOV/2026/50: stockpile size, composition and whereabouts unverifiable
9 Sep 2026	Board adopts a further resolution urging cooperation
17 Sep 2026	Council draft to extend the Panel of Experts fails: 11 in favour, 2 against, 2 abstentions
26 Sep 2026	Panel of Experts mandate lapses without the panel ever having been constituted

Annex B. Using the Primary Documents

Delegates who cite document symbols accurately will be taken more seriously in debate than delegates who cite news reports. The symbols follow fixed patterns.

Pattern	What it is and where to find it
A/RES/00/000	General Assembly resolution, by session and number. Retrieve at undocs.org by typing the symbol directly after the slash, for example undocs.org/en/A/RES/73/546
A/C.1/00/L.00	First Committee draft resolution, where L denotes a limited-distribution draft. This is the form your own draft will take
S/RES/0000	Security Council resolution. Numbering is continuous, not by year
S/2000/000	Security Council document, including letters from Member States such as the E3 snapback notification
GOV/0000/00	IAEA Board of Governors document. Reports on Iran are issued before each quarterly Board and derestricted when the Board so decides
GC(00)/RES/000	IAEA General Conference resolution, with the session in Roman numerals in older documents
INFCIRC/000	IAEA information circular, used for safeguards model texts and for communications from Member States
NPT/CONF.0000/00	NPT Review Conference document, including working papers submitted by States and groups, which are the best single source for bloc positions
CD/0000	Conference on Disarmament document, including national statements in plenary

Three practical notes. First, IAEA Board reports on Iran are restricted when issued and derestricted later, so a report may be described in press coverage before its text is public; cite the symbol and the date of derestriction. Second, the IAEA chronology page is the fastest route to every Director General statement and Board resolution on Iran in date order. Third, for any State position, the national statement to the Conference on Disarmament, to the First Committee general debate, or to an NPT Review Conference is the authoritative text, and all three are published by UNODA.

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